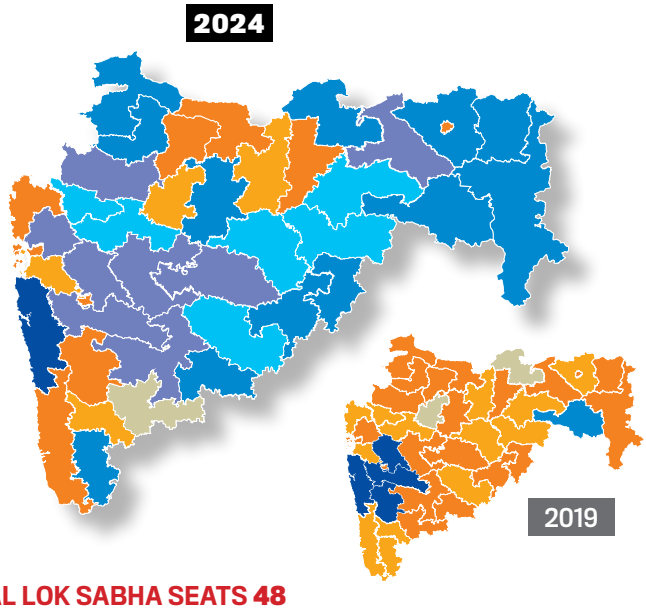
More than numbers and victory margins, the Lok Sabha results in Maharashtra were to be a referendum on the state's political realignments since 2022. The first true test of the public opinion after the splits in the Shiv Sena and the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) in 2022 and 2023 respectively, they were to determine which factions deserved to be called the 'real' Shiv Sena or NCP. It was also to be a verdict—a legitimacy test—on a government forged out of splits and defections, toppling a democratically elected one.

As it happened, it settled the second question—the more national one. It was the aggrieved Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA), the coalition of the Congress and the leftover Sena and NCP factions, that came up trumps at the end of the five-phase election in Maharashtra, winning 30 of the state's 48 seats. That gave the larger Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) its second-highest tally after Uttar Pradesh. The ruling Mahayuti (grand alliance), a part of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), had to rest content with just 17; a rebel Congressman cornered one seat. The outcome will re-energise the MVA, placing it in a strong position for the assembly election later this year. As a senior leader of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) puts it, "This is a win-win situation.... As a regional party, we have few stakes in the Lok Sabha polls. The real battle for us lies in the state assembly. Our numbers will serve as a morale-booster and stem further defections to Shinde." But on this regional plane, the verdict also left that first question partly unanswered. Neither Sena truly dominated, neither got decimated.

In the event, the Congress ended up being the real surprise of the election, winning 13 out of the 17 seats it contested, the highest tally by any party. It was a far cry from the one seat it won in 2019 and the two in 2014. "We lack pan-Maharashtra leaders, but the campaign picked up steam at the local level," says a senior leader. The Congress even won Nanded, where its long-time patent-holder, former chief minister Ashok Chavan, had defected to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The GOP is now ruing having to relinquish its strongholds like Sangli, Mumbai North West, and Mumbai South Central to the Sena(UBT), something that had left the state unit profoundly unhappy. Its unforeseen bounty is now likely to alter the power dynamics within the MVA and give the Congress the upper hand in bargaining for seats in the assembly polls.

Nothing, though, can dampen the current elation in the Sena(UBT), not even the fact that its nine-seat win is only a shade better than the seven seats snaffled by the faction led by chief minister Eknath Shinde. In the endorsement it got for the MVA, which Uddhav Thackeray led from the front, the Sena(UBT) sees a moral victory over a faction that walked away with both the party symbol and the name. "For our party, the battle was not against the BJP, but the Shinde Sena," says the Sena(UBT) leader. The Shinde Sena managed to win just seven seats.

The victory was even sweeter for the Sharad Pawar-led NCP, and not because it won eight out of the 10 seats it contested. It was because his nephew Ajit, who like Shinde, deprived him of the party symbol and name, won just one of the five seats he had been given to contest. "The popular sentiment seems to be against Ajit dada," notes a source close to the Pawars. More significantly, Pawar's daughter Supriya Sule defeated her sister-in-law, Ajit's wife Sunetra, in the family pocket borough of Baramati in one of the most eagerly-watched contests in the country. Sunetra's defeat, says a source, indicates that traditional BJP voters in assembly segments like Khadakwasla did not back the Ajit faction.



TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 48

	BJP	Shiv Sena*	NCP*	CONG	NCP-SP	SS-UBT	REST
2024	9 (26%)	7 (13%)	1 (4%)	13 (17%)	8 (10%)	9 (17%)	1 (13%)
2019	23 (28%)	18* (24%)	4* (16%)	1 (16%)	–	–	2 (16%)

*Vote share in ( ); *2019 numbers are for united parties, 2024 for new splinters*